Cheng Chen

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EDUCATION

Institute of Automation, Chinese Academy of Sciences Sept. 2027 (expected)
Incoming Ph.D. Student, Beijing, China. Supervisor: **Prof. Kaiqi Huang**.

Tongji University Sept. 2023 - Jun. 2027 (expected)
B.Eng. in Communication Engineering, Shanghai, China.
Average score: **92/100** GPA: **4.70** Major rank: **2/85**

MAIN INTERESTS

I explore interesting approaches to solving problems in AI research simply and efficiently, including but not limited to multimodal large models, image/video generation, and embodied intelligence.

PUBLICATIONS

* Equal contribution; † corresponding author.

1) **Cheng Chen***, Yi Xu*, Wenzhuo Lei.
If You Hear It, Help Find It: Orthogonal Knowledge Distillation for Open-Vocabulary Audio-Visual Event Localization. *ACM MM 2026*, accepted.
2) Yi Xu*, **Cheng Chen***, Mufan Cao.
OrthKD: Extracting Generalized Clinical Knowledge from Heterogeneous Teachers for Lightweight Deployment. *IJCAI 2026*, accepted.
3) Wenzhuo Lei, Mufan Cao, Chaorong Ye, Yi Xu, **Cheng Chen**†.
Enabling Visual Reasoning in Text-Only LLMs via Symbolic Scene Descriptions. *IJCNN 2026*, accepted.

PREPRINTS

4) From Scores to Checks: A Human-Annotated Rubric Benchmark for AI-Generated Image Faithfulness. *Preprint, 2026.*
5) What Can Activation-Patching Evidence Establish? *Preprint, 2026.*
6) Follow Me If You Can: Auditing Understanding-to-Generation Transfer. *Preprint, 2026.*
7) Allocation Entropy for Single-Pass Risk Triage in Neural Operators. *Preprint, 2026.*

RESEARCH INTERNSHIPS

Research Intern
Hong Kong University of Science and Technology (Guangzhou) Sept. 2026 - Present
Zhejiang University Jun. 2026 - Sept. 2026
Tongji University Oct. 2025 - Jun. 2026

ACADEMIC SERVICE

Reviewer: ICLR, PRCV, ICME, IJCNN, AAAI.

RESEARCH EXPERIENCE

OV-OrthKD: Open-Vocabulary Audio-Visual Event Localization *ACM MM 2026; co-first author*

- Routed strong visual supervision to the localization path and weaker audio supervision to an orthogonal auxiliary path; used text prototypes to support unseen event categories.
- Reached **0.816 segment average precision** on OV-AVEBench. F1@0.5 improved over the official fine-tuning baseline by **2.7 points** overall and **3.4 points** on unseen categories.

OrthKD: Lightweight Diabetic Retinopathy Screening *IJCAI 2026; co-first author*

- Combined full supervision from a stronger teacher with representation-level transfer from a weaker teacher; orthogonal student projections preserved complementary clinical information.
- Used a combined pool of **132,049** retinal images. A **5.4M**-parameter student reached **0.885 QWK** (quadratic weighted kappa) on EyePACS and improved zero-shot Messidor-2 QWK from **0.507 to 0.728**.

DeepYOLO: Visual Reasoning through Symbolic Scene Descriptions *IJCNN 2026; corresponding author*

- Proposed the initial idea and worked with a junior student, who led implementation and experiments, to connect an object detector with a text-only language model through compact scene reports.
- The pipeline reached **42.3%** visual question answering accuracy on a stratified **5,000-image VQAv2 subset**, versus **38.2%** for scene-graph serialization, using **1/2.5 as many prompt tokens as that baseline**.

Generated Image Evaluation *2026*

- Studied whether generated images satisfy individual requirements in text prompts, using human annotations to separate different types of faithfulness errors.
- Compared lightweight evaluators under matched conditions; examined confidence calibration, supporting image regions, and transfer across generators and datasets.

Reliability in Model Interpretability *2026*

- Studied which functional claims observations from neural-network interventions can support, including cases where matching observed outputs leaves other behavior unresolved.
- Combined mathematical analysis with controlled language-model tests to examine additional measurements and failures on previously unmeasured responses.

Understanding and Generation in Multimodal Models *2026*

- Audited whether training for visual understanding changes image generation in unified multimodal models, focusing on counting and spatial relations.
- Used paired model states and controlled comparisons to distinguish gains in answering questions, effects on generation, and transfer of the requested visual attribute.

Reliability of Neural Operator Predictions *2026*

- Studied risk indicators available within one prediction pass of a neural operator, preserving the predicted physical field and avoiding a separate learned risk head.
- Tested how the scoring representation affects error ranking and acceptance decisions across physical tasks; compared screening quality and computational cost with alternative indicators.

AWARDS AND HONORS

- National First Prize, China Robot and Artificial Intelligence Competition (2026); Team Leader.
- National Second Prize, Global Campus AI Algorithm Elite Competition (2025); Team Leader.
- National Third Prize, Embedded Chip and System Design Contest, FPGA Track (2025); Team Leader.
- Provincial Second Prize, National College Student Mathematics Competition (2024–2025).
- Tongji University Outstanding Student Scholarship, Second Class (2023–2024 and 2024–2025).

TECHNICAL SKILLS

Programming: Python, C/C++, Verilog. **Machine learning:** PyTorch.
Tools: Git, Linux, LaTeX, OpenAI Codex, Claude Code.
Foundations: Machine learning, algorithms, linear algebra, probability, optimization, and signal processing.